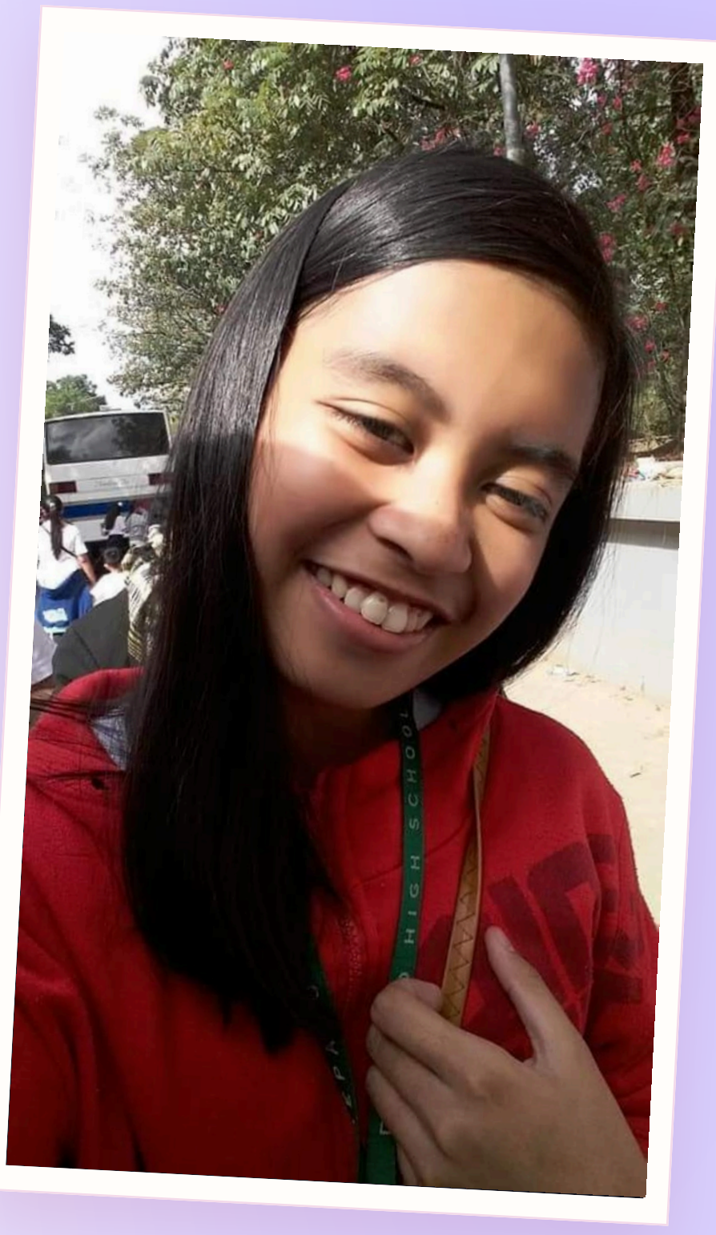
for my love. with all my heart.

some things deserve to be felt.

sorry kung hindi to handwritten na hinahangad mo pero ito ay galing parin sa puso't isipan ko type shit, but medyo unfair pala because how do i put an entire person, all our memories, and everything i still want with you into a few paragraphs? but today, i want to try. you deserve to hear the things i sometimes hide behind pang aasar, random jokes, and all the annoying ways i ask for your attention. beneath all of that is someone who is very, very happy that you were born, and even happier that somehow, out of all the people you could have met, i get to be here loving you.

looking at these pictures, ang dami na rin pala nating versions ng sarili natin na nakilala together. different faces, different places, different things we were worrying about. some pictures are clearer than others, some angles are questionable, and some probably would not have survived your approval process today. but i love having them. they remind me that we were there, that those moments happened, and that somewhere between all those ordinary days, you became someone i wanted beside me in the next picture, and the next, and the next.

i hope you know how much your presence means to me. and yes, i mean even when you are being moody, even when your attitude is at an all-time high, and you are rolling your eyes at me for absolutely no reason. kahit na minsan daig mo pa yung pinakamasungit na pasyente sa ward, you are still, without a doubt, the most **exquisite** person to me. nakakainis ka rin, obviously. kailangan documented din dito para fair. but even when we annoy each other, i never want you to doubt how much i care about you.



if i could give you one thing today, it would be the chance to see yourself through my eyes. you would see someone worth choosing, worth listening to, and worth celebrating. you would see how fiercely dedicated you are, even when you feel behind. you would see how much light you bring into the lives of the people who love you, even on days when your own light is flickering because of stress and endless reviewers. i wish you could see how often i look at you and feel proud, even when you think there is nothing worth being proud of yet.

thank you for the moments we have shared, and for all the small ways you make life feel warmer. for the meals, the coffees, the pictures, the random conversations, and the kind of laughter that makes us look ridiculous in public. we must have more food to try, more stories to tell across the table, more chances to sit and think, ang ganda naman ng kasama ko. kahit busy siya ngumunguya.

and then there are this, a little sun, a little chaos, and the two of us finding our way into the same frame. but i also want the days after the trips, when we are back to our usual routines and there is nothing especially exciting planned.

as you begin another year, i hope there is room for the things that make you happy. i hope you find the courage, a clear mind, and steady hands to face the pnle with confidence. claim na natin yan go go go. i know how much this dream means to you, and i hope that when doubt gets loud, you remember the effort you have already put in. all those hours, all those pages, all those lectures, all those times you kept going even when you would rather have done literally anything else.

there is still so much ahead of you. places to see, dreams to discover, and versions of yourself you have not met yet. i am excited to keep getting to know you as you grow. maybe some things you want will change. maybe life will surprise us. i hope you give yourself permission to figure it out without being cruel to yourself along the way. and i hope you let me stand beside you, cheering for you, listening to you, and occasionally reminding you kung mahal mo pa ako at syempre paamoy pa rin ng kilikili mo at palamutak pa rin ng paa mong kakalusong sa baha.

i cannot promise that every day will be easy. may times na pareho tayong pagod, pareho tayong matigas ang ulo, or hindi agad natin maiintindihan ang isa’t isa. but i want to keep learning how to love you well. to listen properly, to apologize when i should, and to be careful with the things you trust me enough to share. i want my patience to show up in what i do, especially when a moment asks more of me than a sweet message does.

so today, let yourself be celebrated. make a wish. laugh a little louder. take a break from the books. take all the pictures you want, kahit ilang takes pa yan hanggang makuha mo yung perfect angle. i hope you eat something you really like, hear from the people you miss, and have at least one moment when you stop worrying about what comes next and just enjoy being here. you spend so much time preparing for your future. i hope today is kind to the person you are right now.

and when you reach that last picture, i hope you stay there for a moment. look at us then, and look at us now. i love that we have proof of those earlier versions of us. i love that time passed, things changed, and we still have another picture together. i hope someday we look back at the newer photo with the same fondness, with even more memories to place beside it.

i want more pictures with you. more birthdays, more dinners, more places we have never been. more imperfections that turn out to mean everything years later. but most of all, i want to be present enough to enjoy the moments while they are happening. looking at you, i know i am already somewhere i want to be.

happy birthday, my leah, my baby, my love, my sweetheart, my squishy, my bitch, my mommy, my foot fetish, my kilikili, my hun, my mahal, my darling, my dear, my palangga, my dearest, my woman, and **my future rn**. here is to your happiness, to the rn dream you are still chasing, and to all the moments we have yet to share. i am so glad you are here. i am so glad i get to love you.

to all of my heart, kept here for you and only you.

always yours,
shan

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nothing’s gonna hurt you, *baby.*